UNIVERSITY of WASHINGTON

Strategic Plan 2026 to 2030
Built for the Moment – Advancing the Future

I. Introduction

For more than 165 years, the University of Washington has transformed lives and strengthened communities across the state, the Pacific Northwest, the United States and the world. We enter our next chapter as an institution with clarity, confidence and a deep sense of purpose. In a time of rapid technological, scientific and societal change, our greatest strength lies in who we are: a public research university with three campuses and a world-class academic medical center shaped by the people, places and communities we serve. We are strengthened by the diversity of perspectives, backgrounds and experiences within our community, and grounded in enduring values of equity, inclusion and a shared sense of belonging. Our work is energized by discoveries that expand what is possible.

Rooted in Washington and driven by a mission to serve the people of our state, nation and world, the UW is poised to lead with boldness and imagination. We are empowered by possibility and the strength of our collaborations to pursue challenges without boundaries. This strategic plan reflects this moment and that opportunity. It begins with the strengths and values that define us, sets a clear vision for the next five years and establishes four pillars to guide our choices and investments. These pillars foster an inclusive environment where all students, faculty and staff can thrive and contribute to solutions that make our world more equitable and just. The plan also affirms our foundational commitment to mission-driven stewardship so the UW remains strong for generations to come.

II. Building on Our Strengths, Values and a Strategic Focus

As one of the world's leading public research universities, the UW embraces a deep responsibility to serve the people of Washington, the country and the world. Anchored in the Pacific Northwest—a hub of innovation, culture and environmental leadership—our history and future are defined by fearless engagement with the needs, challenges and opportunities of the moment. We honor our legacy by not simply preserving what has been, but by forging what must be. Achieving this requires the University's constant renewal in partnership with our state, nation and society to direct the combined strengths of education, research and engagement toward the most pressing needs.

Across the nation and in Washington, rapid advances in AI and technology are transforming how people work and access opportunity; civic division and polarization are deepening; public resources are tightening; and skepticism about the value of higher education continues to grow. At the same time, UW Medicine faces a shifting landscape in healthcare, and the University must continue to adapt how we research, teach, learn and serve.

The urgency of this moment calls on the University of Washington to lead higher education with focus and bold action through a strategic plan rooted in our strengths, values and enduring public mission. In this environment, the UW's deep and unique partnerships position us to advance progress for Washington and beyond. We move forward with confidence grounded in who we are and inspired by what we will become together.

Shaped by Washington

The UW is uniquely prepared to lead in this moment and shape the future. With world-leading faculty and staff and engaged students, the UW is a top global research university that also prioritizes our local impact in a state renowned for technological, medical and manufacturing innovation, and a deep commitment to societal and environmental stewardship. We unite exceptional strength across the arts and humanities, social sciences, natural sciences, engineering, health sciences and professional fields. We also bring distinctive public-service programs such as the Sea Grant and Space Grant consortia.

Building on these strengths, the UW's talent and expertise has long fueled Washington's innovation economy—from aerospace to biomedical sciences, software to cloud computing—and its creative and cultural sectors. We are poised to help spark the next generation of world-transforming enterprises and a new era of civic health. Our greatest impacts emerge where Washington's strengths and needs meet the UW's broad capabilities: at the intersection of disciplines where ideas blossom, where communities and industries partner with the UW in discovery and where the state's urgent challenges call for bold and imaginative solutions. This spirit of possibility, shaped by the place we call home, drives a legacy of public impact, relentless inquiry and bold innovation.

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Guided by Our Mission, Core Values and a Strategic Focus

The UW is a preeminent public research university dedicated to expanding access and opportunity for students, advancing knowledge and creativity, improving human health and well-being, supporting democratic society and serving the public good. We ground this mission in values that honor diverse identities, experiences and perspectives, create accessible and welcoming environments and foster inclusion, belonging and a sense of social responsibility.

This strategic plan builds on those enduring commitments with focus and intention. The plan does not attempt to capture the full scope of the University's work, nor does it suggest that areas not highlighted lack importance. Much of what we do every day already serves the greater good. Instead, this plan identifies the areas where we must act now to strengthen our foundation and where our distinctive strengths can deliver the greatest impact in the next five years. Specifically, this plan is designed to:

- **Amplify the full force of the UW's mission as a tri-campus public research university and academic health system** by ensuring education, discovery and partnership are accessible and translate into decisive impact for Washington and the world.
- **Set bold goals that position the UW to lead** amid technological transformation, rapid scientific progress, medical advances, climate change and urgent societal needs.
- **Guide strategic choices and investments** so resources are focused where excellence, creativity and regional strengths can deliver the greatest good.

Across our three campuses, schools, colleges and UW Medicine, we will continue vital work that remains essential to our shared success. This plan builds on that foundation by elevating overarching pillars that meet the urgency of this moment and channel the UW's distinctive capabilities and deep spirit of collaboration toward the greatest possible benefit.

III. Vision: A University that brings people, ideas and technologies together in radically innovative ways to improve the lives of people across Washington state and beyond

The University of Washington prepares learners for a changing world by integrating deep human understanding and a clear commitment to fairness, ethical responsibility and civic leadership with technological fluency. We advance discovery and technology through bold and highly collaborative research, and we accelerate innovation that directly improves health, well-being, lived experiences and shared prosperity.

Strengthened by partnerships with communities and collaborators at every level, we show up to listen and work side-by-side with partners to co-design opportunities that reflect community priorities and real needs. Guided by principles of equity and inclusivity, we design and apply technologies in ways that broaden opportunity and access, and ensure benefits are widely shared. We clearly and accessibly communicate our work and take responsibility for showing how our efforts create public value and impact.

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By uniting ethical practice, human insight and new technological possibilities, we create knowledge and deliver solutions that expand opportunity, accelerate progress and create lasting benefits for Washington and beyond. In doing so, we will fulfill our public mission for generations to come.

IV. Four Pillars

Four strategic pillars chart an ambitious path for the University of Washington's next five years. Shaped by the insights and aspirations of our students, trainees, faculty, staff, alumni, government, industry and community partners, these reflect our shared ambition for what the UW can contribute to those we serve. They also guide the actions and investments needed to build a more innovative, equitable and resilient future.

Pillar 1: Delivering High Quality, Debt-Free Education that Unlocks Opportunity

The University of Washington develops the leaders, innovators, humanists and civic champions of the future. We advance knowledge and teach relevant, enduring skills and will amplify them with technology and a focus on creativity, curiosity and analytical thinking. We have a powerful opportunity to expand access to a high-quality education that prepares students for different career paths and civic life, ensuring that a UW education opens doors for every learner. Building on strong partnerships across Washington's rural, urban and tribal communities, as well as industry, governments and non-profits, we will pair expanded access with excellence through expanded financial support, flexible degree and training opportunities and experiences that help students achieve their academic, career and life goals. We will evolve our programs, teaching practices and use of AI and other technologies to meet the demands of a rapidly changing world and workplace. We will also cultivate learning environments where students think critically, engage diverse perspectives and participate fully in civic life. Through this commitment to access and excellence, the UW will equip every learner to thrive today, shape tomorrow and succeed throughout their educational journey.

- **Objective 1.A. Expanding Access to a UW Education**. The UW delivers outstanding educational value and is committed to making education attainable for every student. We will work closely with key partners to pursue bold legislative, philanthropic and industry pathways toward making a University of Washington education debt-free for all Washington undergraduate students, while expanding financial support for graduate, professional and all other students. We will also increase access to popular programs like capacity-constrained majors, grow our high-quality online degree offerings and accelerate efforts to ensure every UW student graduates in a timely fashion.

- **Objective 1.B. Preparing Students for a Changing Workforce**. The UW will continue to redefine how teaching and learning prepares, upskills and reskills Washington's learners for a rapidly changing world and evolving workforce needs. Working in strong partnership with organizations across Washington, including K-12 schools, community colleges, employers and tribal nations, we will reimagine curriculum to expand access

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and prepare students to frame consequential problems, weigh tradeoffs, engage partners and decide when and how to use powerful technology-enabled tools. This work will support both in-person and online learners and emphasize AI literacy, data and digital fluency, ethics, global competencies, equity and civic impact, ensuring real-world value for Washington's communities and economy.

- **Objective 1.C. Evolving Curriculum for Critical Engagement**. The UW teaches students how to think, but not what to think. Our curriculum will strengthen students' ability to analyze complex problems, engage diverse perspectives, ask critical questions and communicate across differences by equipping them with the skills and mindsets for constructive dialogue. We will foster meaningful discourse and experiential learning that deepen understanding and build learners' capacities to evaluate sources and think critically as informed, engaged community members who can help create more connected and responsive societies.

Pillar 2: Engaging in Radical Collaborations for Breakthroughs and Public Benefit

The University of Washington stands at a moment of extraordinary opportunity to empower the next generation of researchers, scholars and innovators whose work will define the future. Washington's communities, industries and governments already rely on the UW as a trusted partner in addressing urgent challenges, and our comprehensive excellence and deep community roots position us to meet this moment by integrating our strengths in new ways. We will harness the grassroots creativity across our fields and campuses and intentionally elevate this excellence, protecting what we do best while expanding our world-leading research capacity to translate discovery into public benefit across Washington, the nation and the world. Through trusted partnerships with communities and across sectors, we will accelerate breakthroughs in science, technology and creative work, and offer invaluable analysis that helps leaders make hard decisions in service of the public good. We will invest strategically to drive significant gains that will strengthen communities, fuel the state's economy, address climate change and generate long-lasting public impact. By strengthening agile, cutting-edge infrastructure and recruiting, developing and retaining the excellent faculty who power our research enterprise, we will deliver solutions of lasting value and set new standards for how universities collaborate with communities to shape a healthier, fairer and more sustainable future.

- **Objective 2.A. Co-Designing Partnerships that Redefine What is Possible**. The UW is one of the nation's leading public universities in federal research funding, fueling creativity and uniting disciplines to tackle some of the world's most complex, interconnected challenges. We will advance our co-design practices with communities, moving from effective collaboration to exemplary partnership-driven innovation, creating authentic partnerships with non-governmental organizations, governments, philanthropists, private sector businesses and global institutions to drive innovation at scale.

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- **Objective 2.B. Launching Breakthroughs that Shape Tomorrow**. The UW's extraordinary track record of discovery and invention has delivered remarkable global impact. We will capitalize on opportunities to accelerate excellence by driving breakthroughs in health, basic science, professional practice and technology that address challenges in areas such as behavioral health, civic health, climate change, population health and more. Through strategic, targeted investments, the UW will expand opportunities across fields while laying the groundwork for the next generation of technology-enabled discoveries, real-world translation and partnerships that strengthen Washington's communities, fuel the state's economy and prosperity and generate solutions with lasting global impact.

- **Objective 2.C. Building Nimble Capacity to Accelerate Impact**. The UW will strengthen research excellence by diversifying and stabilizing funding, modernizing the systems that support our research enterprise, centering key questions of community leaders and recruiting, developing and retaining excellent faculty. We will invest in advanced infrastructure, shared resources and leading-edge technology, including AI-enabled tools and automation, to create flexible, efficient and user-friendly research environments. We will also cultivate a system and culture that reward bold ideas, encourage interdisciplinary collaboration and accelerate breakthrough discoveries. Reducing administrative complexity that hinders collaboration will contribute to a resilient, high-impact research ecosystem that helps protect existing research strengths, advance science and upholds our responsibility as stewards of public and private investments.

Pillar 3: Strengthening Healthier Communities Where Everyone Can Thrive

Communities across Washington and the five-state WWAMI (Washington, Wyoming, Alaska, Montana and Idaho) region face a pivotal moment as workforce shortages, rapid technological change and persistent inequities reshape what it takes to live healthy and fulfilling lives. By expanding access to high quality, equitable care and strengthening the health workforce, we will ensure that innovation leads to healthier lives and stronger communities. UW Medicine and our health sciences schools will collaborate more deeply with partners across the University to harness big data, AI and emerging technologies, accelerating breakthroughs and reimagining care delivery to expand access. By uniting world-class research, data and expertise across disciplines to address the upstream, interconnected factors that shape how long and how well people live, we will advance human health and the economic, environmental and social foundations that help communities here and around the world thrive.

- **Objective 3.A. Expanding Access to Care**. UW Medicine will be the healthcare provider of choice in the Puget Sound region. We will expand access to high-quality, equitable care for patients locally and in rural, underserved and tribal communities by strengthening the connection between research discovery and clinical practice and deploying innovative technologies and outreach. As the state's public healthcare system serving the most vulnerable, we view expanding access and promoting health equity as essential to our mission. We will lead at the intersection between engineering and

medicine to create the hospital and clinic of the future, expanding and modernizing our UW Medical Center – Montlake campus, leveraging technology to improve the patient experience and elevating the quality of care. Through community-based education that allows students to prepare for health careers without relocating, the UW will train and support a larger, interdisciplinary workforce ready to expand access and meet the evolving health needs of Washington and the wider WWAMI region.

- **Objective 3.B. Driving Technological Innovation that Meets the Needs of Humanity**. The UW is at the forefront of medical care, health science and the translation of technological innovation into impact. We will lead in the responsible use of big data, AI and other emerging technologies to advance next-generation healthcare, with a focus on research and applications that accelerate discovery and measurably improve health outcomes. UW Medicine and our health sciences schools will deepen collaboration with data- and technology-focused fields across the University to develop new approaches to delivering care, strengthening clinical translation and expanding innovations that directly benefit patients and communities.

- **Objective 3.C. Shaping Healthier Populations**. The UW will help build healthier, more resilient communities by addressing the interconnected economic, environmental and social factors that shape how long and how well people live. Anchored by interdisciplinary collaboration across fields and deep community and global partnerships, we will turn research into concrete, community-level solutions that support longer, healthier and more fulfilling lives.

Pillar 4: Stewarding and Growing the People and Resources that Support Our Mission and Strategic Initiatives

The University of Washington stewards our people, resources and places to create lasting value for Washington, the nation and the world. Guided by our public mission, we sustain the University's strength by leading with our values, agility and long-term vision. Stewardship is the foundation of this strategic plan, offering the people, resources, systems and financial resilience needed to deliver on our shared goals. By strengthening this foundation, the UW will cultivate a more inclusive culture, elevate operational excellence and spark innovation across our three campuses, UW Medicine and other UW locations. In turn, this will enable the other three pillars of this plan to achieve their full potential and ensure the University remains one of the best places in the world to work and learn.

- **Objective 4.A. Implementing Strategic Alignment for Operational Excellence**. The UW will align our operations to be more effective, service-oriented and responsive, positioning us to lead higher education in redefining how universities operate. We will better steward our resources on behalf of the public, including advancing decarbonization of the UW's energy systems. We will take technology-enabled approaches to building the shared environments that modernize how core administrative services are delivered and support sustainable institutional growth. We

will pursue the structural changes needed to align our administrative operating model with the evolving needs of the University's academic mission. We will also promote a culture of continuous improvement that enhances service quality, elevates institutional performance and enables employees to focus on work that matters most.

- **Objective 4.B. Strengthening Our Financial Future**. To advance our mission, the UW must be financially strong, agile and adaptable. The financial model of the past will not sustain the University's ambitions for the future. We will seek creative solutions to revenue generation, anticipate and address revenue challenges, strengthen the finances of UW Medicine and other units facing budget challenges and manage risks with clarity and discipline to safeguard the University's enduring vitality. We will also enhance transparency and accountability through Incentive Based Budgeting to align University resources, and those from the UW's next philanthropic campaign, with initiatives that deliver the greatest impact for the people and communities we serve.

- **Objective 4.C. Working as One UW**. The UW will leverage and advance the complementary strengths of the Bothell, Seattle and Tacoma campuses to enrich education, community engagement and student career readiness. We will strengthen our tri-campus network by expanding shared courses, simplifying policies such as intercampus credit transfers and improving other processes to allow students, faculty and academic resources to move more easily across campuses.

- **Objective 4.D. Thriving Together**. The UW's public impact is powered by the people who bring our mission to life. We will invest in every employee's growth by enhancing leadership and professional development opportunities, strengthening career pathways and building systems that support equitable and sustainable workloads. We will also champion a culture where mental health and well-being are embraced as essential for learning, discovery and meaningful work. Together, we will cultivate an environment grounded in service, accountability and the opportunity for everyone to flourish.

V. Conclusion

Together, these strategic commitments position the University of Washington to lead with boldness and imagination in a time of extraordinary possibility. Guided by our values and strengthened by deep partnerships, we will elevate education, innovation and collaboration by bringing together human insight, ideas and technological advances in ways that create enduring benefit for people and communities. By investing in our communities and uniting our strengths around the needs of this moment, we will expand opportunity, accelerate progress and shape a healthier, more equitable future. To realize this vision, the entire UW community will advance these priorities in classrooms, labs, clinics and communities, supporting our students, strengthening our workforce, deepening community partnerships and advancing the ideas and research that improve lives across Washington and the world.

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